

CASE STUDY

Self-Service Order Returns & Refunds

Business requirements for an e-commerce returns flow, written to remove agents from the standard case without losing fraud and finance controls.

6.5 → <3 days

time-to-refund

~40%

support ticket reduction

70%+

self-serve completion target

Situation

Returns were fully manual: customers emailed or called support, an agent judged eligibility case-by-case, and refunds waited on a separate warehouse confirmation. That produced a 6.5-day average time-to-refund, ~12,000 return tickets a month, and no consistent audit trail for finance — all avoidable with a self-serve flow for the common case.

My role

Sole BA on the initiative. Ran discovery with Support, Finance, and Warehouse Ops; wrote the BRD and user stories; and negotiated the eligibility rules with Engineering and Finance before handoff to the sprint team.

Key decisions

- **Auto-approve only standard cases, not everything —**

Full automation looked attractive on paper, but Engineering flagged fraud exposure (serial returners laundering used items through a rules engine with no human check). I added a manual-review threshold for high-value (\$300+) and final-sale items instead of shipping either "fully manual" or "fully automated."

- **Gate refunds on inspection status, not label creation —**

Finance's hard requirement was that no refund fires until the warehouse confirms the item arrived and passed inspection. This meant the refund trigger had to key off a WMS status change, not off the customer shipping the item — a distinction that avoids refunding for items that are lost or never sent back.

- **Kept exchanges out of scope —**

Exchanges looked like a natural add-on but touch inventory reservation logic that wasn't ready. Cutting them from v1 kept the initial scope shippable in one quarter rather than stalling on a dependency outside the team's control.

Outcome (targets set at handoff)

- Time-to-refund: 6.5 days → under 3 business days post-inspection
- Return-related support tickets: ~40% reduction (roughly 4,800 tickets/month)
- Self-serve completion rate: 70%+ of eligible returns handled with zero agent touch

Artifact

Full BRD — including user stories, acceptance criteria, RACI, risk register, and success metrics — is attached as a companion document.